



During your pregnancy, you will be offered a series of **ultrasounds and tests** to monitor the **growth** and **development** of your baby, and to ensure that your own body is dealing well with your pregnancy. **Ultrasounds** provide a wonderful opportunity to “**meet**” **your baby**, and various **tests** check for abnormalities.

Ultrasounds and tests

What you might expect to happen

The blood, urine, and blood pressure tests that are routinely offered throughout your pregnancy are there to keep a close eye on you and your baby. The goal of these tests is to identify warning signs before they turn into problems. For example, if a blood test shows low levels of hemoglobin, this can indicate low iron levels, a sign of anemia; high blood pressure and/or protein in the urine are symptoms of preeclampsia.

You will also be given ultrasounds, which use sound waves to visualize your baby in the uterus. They are painless and carry no known risks to you or your baby. Aside from enabling you to see your baby, they also give a good assessment of how he is growing and developing, even down to checking the structure of his heart. They also indicate any issues that you might have, such as fibroids or a weak cervix. You will usually be offered a minimum of two ultrasounds, one between 8 and 14 weeks, the first ultrasound, and a second at around 18 to 20 weeks called the anatomy scan (ultrasound).

During your pregnancy you will also be given the option of having prenatal tests that check for various genetic or chromosomal abnormalities such as Down syndrome. Some of these assess your risk of carrying a baby with an abnormality and involve a blood test combined with measuring fluid at the back of the neck

known as the nuchal translucency test via ultrasound. If there is any concern that your baby might have a congenital abnormality of any kind, you'll be offered further tests that are more invasive, such as chorionic villus sampling or an amniocentesis. These ultrasounds and tests enable the doctor taking care of you to gain as clear a picture as possible of your baby before he is born.

You will always have a choice as to whether you consent to the ultrasound or test in question; none of them is compulsory. However, all the tests are there to ensure that the appropriate care is given to you and your baby. Feel free to discuss any concerns you have with your doctor before a test takes place. He or she will be able to talk you through the details and risks of all the procedures so that you can make an informed decision.

Your time line of care

On the opposite page is a time line of tests and ultrasounds that you can expect during the course of your pregnancy. Unless there is a specific reason (such as a family history of twins) for having an early ultrasound, the tests and ultrasounds usually begin with the first appointment (see p.80). Some of these are ultrasounds and tests that every pregnant woman will be offered; others are exceptional, depending upon your circumstances. All of the tests are to monitor the health and well-being of you and your baby.